Media Exposure and Feelings Toward Trump: The Impact of Attempted Assassination During the 2024 Presidential Election Campaign

Abstract:

What impact does a violent attack against a political leader have on cross-partisan candidate sympathy? We address this question by examining the attempted assassination of Donald Trump during the 2024 presidential election campaign. We specifically investigate how social media exposure and partisan affiliation together shaped emotional evaluations toward Donald Trump before and after the assassination attempt in July 2024. We test three expectations: that Republicans should experience an increase in positive emotional evaluations towards Trump, that Independents should likewise demonstrate an increase in positive emotional evaluations towards Trump, and that Democrats should show a decrease in emotional evaluations towards Trump. Using a multistep analytical strategy that includes MICE imputation, propensity score matching, and proportional odds and partial proportional odds modeling, we found mixed support for our hypothesis, with strong support confirming the Republican hypothesis, mixed findings for the Independent hypothesis, and surprisingly the opposite effect among Democrats. These findings suggest that the effects of social media exposure will vary based on partisan identity and political context.

Keywords:

Trump, Political Polarization, American Politics, Voting Behavior

Word Count:

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Statements and Declarations

Declaration of conflicting or competing interest

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Data availability

All data used is publicly available on the American National Election Study website: https://electionstudies.org/data-center/ Replication scripts are available upon request.

Introduction

While the American political system is historically no stranger to political assassinations, such events have typically produced shock in both the political and psychological sense among the public. From fear and anxiety to uncertainty both about what may happen next and the potential stability of the democratic experiment, political assassinations have produced negative cognitive and institutional outcomes. However, when such events occur before an election, common sense suggests the victim's party or related candidates will see more support. In contemporary American politics, however, where partisan identities have become deeply entrenched and affective polarization dominates public life, such reactions are not self-evident. What impact does a violent attack against a political leader have on cross-partisan candidate sympathy? Our study addresses this question by examining the public opinion effects of the attempted assassination of Donald Trump during the 2024 presidential election campaign. Specifically, it investigates whether the attack influenced voters' support for Trump based upon social media exposure and variations in partisan identity.

We argue that the assassination attempt had variable impacts on support for Trump based on partisan identity but overall did not change the fundamental relationship between voters and the parties with which they identify. A key reasoning behind this outcome is that affective polarization has only increased in American politics, and so the public is potentially more divided than ever given the emotional dimension of affective polarization pushes people away. We suggest the driving force in this relationship is the role of social media in promoting polarizing emotions and reinforcing existing partisanship. As such, Republicans should feel increasingly warmer towards Trump, while Democrats should feel increasingly colder towards Trump. However, Independent affiliates should be much more susceptible to effects of social

media and thus feel warmer towards Trump due to the attempted assassination. Indeed, this effect should be most evident among Independents because, as more moderate voters, they should find themselves less inclined to have a baseline negative or positive feeling towards Trump relative to the two major (polarized) parties. We test these hypotheses using a multi-step analytical strategy, which includes the use of multiple imputation via chained equations (MICE), propensity score matching, and the estimation of proportional odds and partial proportional odds models using the 2024 American National Election Survey (ANES) pilot study dataset and the 2024 time series datasets. We found partial support for our hypotheses, which suggest that social media exposure has variable effects upon partisan affiliates when it comes to feelings towards Donald Trump both pre-assassination attempt and post-assassination attempt.

Theory

In the wake of salient or tragic events, like an attempted political assassination, media exposure of such events can potentially force voters to update their preferences and perspectives on politics. These processes are heterogeneous across the mass public and are conditioned by selective exposure and partisan affiliation. To be precise, social media exposure of a highly salient event, like an attempted assassination, can produce emotions within voters that, in turn, impact their perspectives towards candidates. However, existing voter perceptions matter and can potentially be fixed based on their partisan identity. The extent to which media can push a voter to change their mind about a candidate or issue, and thus update their cognitive evaluations, is thus determined by the extent to which they have developed a strong, affectively polarized partisan identity.

Media Exposure as the Central Force in Contemporary Political Interpretation

Modern political communication as a primary source of information on politics structures how potential voters perceive and evaluate political information on an emotional level. Indeed, emotions are generally understood as short-lived, intense, and directed (Fiske & Taylor 1991) mental states that represent "evaluative, [and] valenced reaction[s] to events, agents, or objects" with variations in intensity (Nabi 1999, 295; Ortony et al. 1988). Across media emotional reactions arise not only because of the sequence of events, but due to the emotional tone (Dunaway 2013) and strategic framing or angle (Ridout and Fowler 2012) adopted in the story in addition to the underlying context. In this way, modern political communication via media outlets can have significant impacts on how people feel about politicians and political events.

Even so, emotional appeals across the mainstream media are not rare. In fact, a study on television advertising by Kaid & Johnston (2001) found that emotional appeals were much more common than logical appeals across the five decades they examined. Moreover, when emotional appeals are prevalent but the accompanying information is subjectively unfavorable, individuals tend to rely more on personal interpretation than factual content for both acceptance and recall, which may further narrow their focus to isolated segments of information (Gaines et al. 2007). This phenomenon is especially problematic given studies have found that negative political messages are typically remembered more vividly than positive ones due to the variations in emotional reactions elicited (Lang 1991; Newhagen and Reeves 1991). Consequently, this implies the media environment does not merely transmit information but structures emotional reactions and narrows cognitive focus, which sets the stage for identity-based processing.

In terms of identity-based processing, there is a rich literature demonstrating that people process politically relevant information through their partisan identification (Bartels 2002;

Druckman et al. 2013; Lodge and Taber 2013; Theodoridis 2017). Following social identity theory, a voter's social groups will ultimately become a significant part of their self-definition due to the formation and reinforcement of emotional and psychological attachments to those groups (Iyengar et al. 2012, 2019). When social groups polarize, so too do individuals attached to those groups harden identities to avoid alienation (Seeman, 1975). This phenomenon is exacerbated by the role of partisan labels, which serve as powerful and relatively low-cost information cues and heuristics in complex political environments, particularly for those with limited political knowledge (Aldrich 1995; Lau and Redlawsk 2001; Sniderman et al. 1991; Carpini and Keeter 1996; Page and Shapiro 1992; Kahneman and Tversky 1972; Lau and Redlawsk 2001). Such cues assist even the most uninformed voters in making politically relevant decisions.

From here, media environments can generally strengthen group consciousness. A group consciousness refers to a group's politicized in-group identification, which incorporates beliefs about both the group's social standing and the collective strategies through which the group can best realize its goals and improve that social standing (Chong & Rogers, 2004; Conover, 1988; McClain et al., 2009; McClain & Stewart, 2006; Miller et al., 1981). As media coverage consistent with a group's identity accumulates, group consciousness becomes increasingly activated, leading individuals in the group away from simple group membership and towards action and participation (Miller et al., 1981). This dynamic underwrites the ideological congruence of groups and their respective members (Golder and Lloyd 2014), which leads to strong partisan affiliation in elections that ultimately predict vote choice (Ansolabehere et al. 2008; Bartels 2000). Moreover, this dynamic helps explain why polarization since the 1970s has remained a core feature of the American political system (Abramowitz and Saunders 2008;

Grumbach 2018). In short, as group consciousness has increased, polarized individuals within partisan groups have progressively moved towards favoring their in-group at the expense of out-groups.

In contemporary politics, an affective form of polarization has taken root and yielded significant negative externalities for scholars interested in democracy (Somer and McCoy 2018). Affective polarization is a deeper, more cognitive oriented concept that moves beyond a simple ideological divide between voters, turning instead to a growing dislike and distrust of the out-party and their supporters (Iyengar et al. 2019). Indeed, research has suggested that voters identifying with parties reflecting their ideological positions has been increasing (Levendusky 2009), which reduces the likelihood co-partisans will encounter conflicting political ideas and identities (Roccas and Brewer 2002). As parties social distance from each other while simultaneously adopting partisan stereotypes (Ahler and Sood 2018), voters' ideological positions increasingly shift away from those on the opposing ideological spectrum due to a cognitive dimension that produce feelings of "animosity" between members of opposing parties (Iyengar et al. 2019, 130). Indeed, Mason (2016) suggests affective polarization is, at least in part, an emotional reaction to parties and partisanship. Exposure to partisan media can sharpen this divide (Levendusky and Malhotra 2016), although especially among individuals predisposed to strong identity commitments (Druckman et al. 2018). As media consumption and exposure is at partially a self-selective endeavor (Stroud 2008, 2011), heterogeneous digital networks can mix cross-cutting cues with identity-consistent content, thus sustaining the polarization cycle (Bakshy et al. 2015). The resulting system is one where people consume favorable media, which continuously pushes people across the political spectrum closer to their respective partisan affiliates, and farther from the out-group and its affiliates.

The Identity Framework During an Attempted Political Assassination

Within this framework, emotions produced by political media play a significant role in how people perceive and interpret events. For example, anger often emerges when rhetoric contradicts core beliefs, although this is especially pronounced among individuals with stronger identifications or more extreme attitudes (Bakker et al. 2021). Research has even suggested that anger can push individuals toward charismatic and populist leaders (Webster and Albertson 2022), potentially furthering extremism. Similarly, negative forms of media, such as attack ads, reliably elicit negative emotions while shaping candidate evaluations (Chang 2001). In an identity-centered media environment, emotional responses become the proximate mechanism through which exposure translates into motivated reasoning, preference updating, and participation (Iyengar et al. 2019; Lodge and Taber 2013; Lau and Redlawsk 2001).

During a high salience event, the emotional channels through which the media operate become amplified and can have significant impacts on people. High salience events can spark anger among a targeted victim's supporters, which can at least temporarily weaken individual-level commitments to democratic values via lower levels of tolerance for the opposition (Webster 2020). Such events can be perceived by citizens as threatening, with the natural reaction an increased likelihood of scapegoating, or attributing blame to out-groups or elites, as a means of minimizing uncertainty and perceived risk (Douglas 1995; Rothschild et al. 2012). However, these conditions can also generate conspiracy-based cognition (Van Prooijen and Douglas 2018), which becomes dangerous as the introduction of misinformation into a belief system can persist over time despite attempts at correction (Thorson 2016).

As these dynamics vary across individuals and contexts, so too does group consciousness fluctuate depending on political sophistication and social conditions (A. H. Miller et al. 1981). Higher sophisticates are better at discerning factual content (Brady and Sniderman 1985) and are simultaneously better at translating information into behavior than low sophisticates (P. R. Miller 2011). The degree to which citizens engage in political motivated reasoning, however, is dependent on the relevance of social conditions and specific topic to other parts of their identity (Boyer et al. 2022) given people experience distinct emotions depending on how they perceive sources of potential harm (Thomas et al. 2009). As people often self-select information sources (Stroud 2008, 2011), this suggests selective exposure and prior attitudes moderate media effects, which can be seen among those with more extreme attitudes who shift further towards extremism under partisan news (Levendusky 2013).

Applied to a figure like Donald Trump, media coverage of a violent, high salience event can produce immediate, ideologically charged reactions among both co-partisans and opponents, which in turn can heighten in-group solidarity, out-group animus, and identity-protective cognition depending on a voter's partisan-ideological identity. History has provided some examples of potential reactions to high salience events in the American case, as Appleton (2000) suggests the assassination of John F. Kennedy triggered an immediate and overwhelming emotional response culminating in both a national mourning period and soaring sympathy for both Kennedy and his political party. Such a rise in public esteem is not unique to Kennedy, however, but aligns with a broader pattern associated with attempted political assassination where the victim gains enhanced public support and sympathy that solidifies or elevates their legacy (Appleton 2000). In a more similar case to Trump's own, the assassination attempt on

Ronald Reagan promoted a boost in popularity like that of John F. Kennedy, with Lanoue (1989) suggesting Reagan experienced an 8 point boost in popularity post-event.

Yet, unlike both Kennedy and Reagan, Trump was able to walk away from the attack with minor injuries. As a matter of fact, Trump's degree of injury was shown to be minimal in July of 2024, well before the 2024 election (Mitovich 2024; Suter 2024). Indeed, several forms of media proceeded to continuously and consistently promote Trump's actions post-assassination, although especially in the case of social media. This particular form of media has become the dominant form for news consumption purposes as it can quickly and thoroughly spread news among voters and thus may be contributing to polarization (Bail et al. 2018). However, this effect may potentially be an indirect one promoted through mediated civic awareness (Boulianne 2016).

We suggest the circumstances surrounding Trump's case in the contemporary political world has a variable impact based on partisan identity. Those partisans who are ideologically congruent with Trump (i.e., Republicans) as well as those susceptible to swaying (i.e., Independents) should experience sympathizing effects while affective polarization should prevent Democrats from shifting positions. We thus expect Democratics, Independents, and Republicans to hold variable levels of support for Trump after the assassination attempt.

In other words, constant social media exposure that both reinforces polarization and attempts to change minds should have impacted some voters more emotionally than others, although especially among politically aware individuals as they are selective and more likely to "receive" elite messages based on their prior attitudes (Zaller 1992). Those who identify with the Republican party should be increasingly willing to receive such messages given Trump's Republican affiliation than Democrats who are likely in direct opposition to Trump due to their

partisan identity. Independents, on the other hand, should be much more susceptible to social media messaging regarding the assassination attempt and thus be more willing to sympathize. We thus test three hypotheses.

H1: Social media exposure will increase support for Trump post-assassination attempt relative to pre-assassination attempt among Republicans. (*The Republican Hypothesis*)

H2: Social media exposure will increase support for Trump post-assassination attempt relative to pre-assassination attempt among Independents. (*The Independent Hypothesis*)

H3: Social media exposure will decrease support for Trump post-assassination attempt relative to pre-assassination attempt among Democrats. (*The Democrat Hypothesis*)

Data and Methodology

We draw on two independent samples from the 2024 American National Election Studies (ANES) to test our hypotheses. The first is the 2024 ANES Pilot Study, fielded from February 20 to March 1, 2024 by YouGov, which provides 1,500 weighted cases designed for population inference (American National Election Studies 2024) and encompasses the pre-assassination attempt period.[1]

The second is the full 2024 ANES Timer Series Election study fielded by the Survey Research Operations unit at the University of Michigan's Survey Research Center between August 3, 2024 and November 5, 2024, providing a substantially larger cross-sectional sample at

[1]The full pilot study contains 1,909 observations. However, following ANES documentation, 409 additional unweighted cases were excluded from all analyses as they are not intended to contribute to population inference and lack the survey weights necessary for valid population-level inference. These comprise 296 partial interviews and 113 unmatched respondents.

5,521 weighted cases (American National Election Studies 2025). This encompasses the post-assassination attempt period. In this way, our study considers the assassination attempt on July 13, 2024, as a cut-off period, such that differences in similar variables across the samples can be treated in a pre- vs post-event format. As such, the pilot study will be referred to as the pre-assassination attempt period moving forward, while the 2024 election study will be referred to as the post-assassination attempt period.

Variables

Since the pilot study was used to test the survey in preparation for the full election study, we only used variables that were included in both the pilot and full election datasets. While this was a limiting factor, we nevertheless include several important variables available. The dependent variable is respondents' affective evaluation of Donald Trump, measured using the ANES 100-point feeling thermometer running from a scale of 0 (negatively, or very cold) to 100 (positively, or very warm). This consisted of variable "cand_trump" in the pre-assassination attempt dataset , and V241157 in the post-assassination attempt dataset. Raw thermometer scores were recoded into an ordered five-category variable: Very Cold (0), Cold (1 through 30), Neutral (31 through 60), Warm (61 through 99), and Very Warm (100). This operationalization captures meaningful distributional shifts across the full range of affective response. Moreover, treating the outcome as ordered rather than continuous is appropriate given the non-normal distribution of feeling thermometer responses, which are typically concentrated at the endpoints and round numbers, and avoids the assumptions of linearity and equal spacing inherent in OLS-based approaches.

The primary independent variable is social media news exposure, operationalized as a binary treatment indicator distinguishing respondents who consumed political news via social

media from those who did not. In the Pilot Study, respondents who reported using social media to follow or discuss political news (poldisc_socmed_10) were coded as treated (1), while those reporting no such exposure were coded as control (0). In the Pre-Election survey, respondents were asked whether they used each of eight specific social media platforms for political news (V242577a through V242577h). These platforms included: Facebook, Twitter, Instagram, Reddit, YouTube, Snapchat, TikTok, as well as an Other category for any additional options. Any reported platform use was coded as treated (1), while not reporting any social media use was coded as control (0).

Party identification was included as a moderating variable and measured using the standard ANES seven-point scale collapsed to three categories: Republican, Independent, and Democrat. In the pre-assassination attempt dataset, this is question "pid7," while it is V241227x in the post-assassination attempt dataset. As we suggest the effect of social media news exposure on Trump affect depends on whether someone identifies as a Republican, Independent, or Democrat, we interact the treatment with party identification across our models.

All models include the following pre-treatment covariates. First, we include a generalized social trust variable that takes the form of a five-category ordered measure. This is "trust_soctrust" in the pre-assassination attempt dataset, and V241234 in the post-assassination attempt dataset. It is coded Trust Never (1), Trust About Half of the Time (2), Trust Most of the Time (3), and Trust Always (4). We also include a dichotomous employment status variable. This is "status_work" in the pre-assassination attempt dataset, and V241471 in the post-assassination attempt dataset. It is coded worked for pay in the past week (1) versus did not (0).

Furthermore, we included several demographic controls including sex, race, and education. The sex variable takes the form of "gender" in the pre-assassination attempt dataset

and V241550 in the post-assassination attempt dataset, coded female (1) and male (0). The race variable in the pre-assassination attempt dataset is "race," while it is V241501x in the post-assassination attempt dataset. This variable is White (1), Black (2), Hispanic (3), Asian (4), and Other (5). The last demographic control variable is Education, which is taken from "educ" in the pre-assassination attempt dataset and V241463 in the post-assassination attempt dataset. Education was coded 1 for no high school degree (1), high School graduate (2), some college (3), associate's degree (4), bachelor's degree (5), and post-graduate or higher (6).

We also include continuous day-level time fixed effect capturing the respondent's interview date. This takes the form of each survey's starting date given no survey took more than 1 day to complete. For the pre-assassination attempt, this is the "starttime" variable, while it is the V243050 variable in post-assassination attempt dataset. The interview date variable is coded as a sequential integer across both survey waves, with pre-assassination attempt dates assigned values 1 through 9, and post-assassination attempt dates assigned values 11 through 105, preserving the temporal ordering across waves. A dichotomous dataset indicator (pre-assassination attempt versus post-assassination attempt) is additionally included in the pooled sample to account for systematic baseline differences between survey waves. Across all models, design weights provided by ANES were incorporated to ensure estimates are representative of the target population.

Analytical Strategy

Since questions in each dataset are collected via probability sampling, we opt to use a series of methodological tools to ensure accuracy across analyses with several robustness checks. Estimation proceeded in three stages: multiple imputation using MICE techniques to address missing data, propensity score matching to improve causal identification, and finally outcome

modeling for inference with each dataset separately first followed by a pooled sample analysis for additional robustness and comparison. Imputation followed by matching and subsequent modeling is recommended when both missing data and possible confounding factors are present given it ensures that propensity scores are estimated on complete data while accounting for the uncertainty in the imputation of the missing values through subsequent stages of analysis (Pishgar et al. 2021). In addition, after testing the proportional odds assumption, we estimated both proportional odds and partial proportional odds models based on Brant test results, followed by average marginal effects.

Multiple Imputation

First, we addressed missing data problems using Multiple Imputation via Chained Equations (MICE) in R using the mice package (van Buuren and Groothuis-Oudshoorn 2011). One hundred imputed datasets were generated with 100 iterations each. Imputation models were tailored to variable type: proportional odds logistic regression (*polr*) for the ordered five-category dependent variable, logistic regression (*logreg*) for our dichotomous variables, and polytomous logistic regression (*polyreg*) for unordered categorical variables.

Propensity Score Matching

To strengthen causal identification by reducing potential confounding from observed pre-treatment characteristics, propensity score matching was conducted using the *MatchThem* package in R (Pishgar et al. 2021). This process requires matching separately within each imputed dataset followed by pooling matched estimates according to Rubin's (1987) combining rules. We estimated the Average Treatment Effect on the Treated (ATT), which is the effect of social media news exposure among those who were actually exposed to political news via social media. Moreover, we used nearest-neighbor matching with replacement, coupled with a caliper

of 0.2 standard deviations of the logit of the propensity score to prevent poor-quality matches between treated and control units with dissimilar propensity scores (Austin 2011). In this way, our approach allows discarding units outside the region of common propensity score support from both treatment and control groups, which ensures that causal comparisons are restricted to the region of covariate overlap while avoiding extrapolation.

The propensity score modeling step included all pre-treatment covariates, and covariate balance before and after matching was assessed using standardized mean differences, with $|d| < 0.10$ considered the threshold for acceptable balance (Stuart 2010). For the pooled sample data, we included the dichotomous dataset indicator as a covariate because of the significant differences between the pilot (pre-assassination attempt) and time series dataset (post-assassination attempt). Including this as a covariate in matching prevents cross-survey noise form contaminating the pooled sample. Final analysis weights were constructed by multiplying matching weights by ANES survey design weights, ensuring that both confounding adjustment and survey representativeness are reflected in all estimates. The matched results were checked using balance plot options found in the *cobalt* package and found to be well balanced. The matched data provide significant improvements relative to the unadjusted data by significantly reducing bias.[2]

Proportional Odds and Partial Proportional Odds Modeling

We first estimated a proportional odds logistic regression within each matched imputed dataset using the MASS package's *polr* function (Venables and Ripley 2002). The proportional odds model is appropriate for the ordered five-category feeling thermometer outcome because it

[2] The balance plots from matching for the split sample and pooled samples can be found in Appendix Figures 1 and 2. The pooled sample balance plot is in Appendix Figure 3. These figures show significant improvements in estimates relative to the unadjusted data.

models the cumulative probability of falling at or below each threshold of our Trump feeling thermometer as a function of predictors, under the assumption that predictor effects are constant across thresholds. Parameter estimates were pooled across the 100 imputed datasets using Rubin's (1987) combining rules. As a specification check, all models were re-estimated using the ordinal package's *clm* function, which implements the same proportional odds model via a different algorithm. Results were substantively identical across implementations.

The proportional odds assumption was then formally assessed using the Brant test (Brant, 1990) on the matched samples. Starting with the pre-assassination attempt period, the omnibus test indicated that the parallel regression assumption holds globally for the sample ($\chi^2 = 61.31$, df = 63, $p = 0.54$), providing a baseline justification for the standard ordered logit specification. However, several individual predictors showed evidence of non-proportional effects, which may reduce the reliability of individual-level test results and likely contributes to the discrepancy between the passing omnibus result and the significant individual-level violations.

To assess whether relaxing the proportionality constraint for the offending predictors meaningfully improved model fit, a partial proportional odds model was estimated using the *ordinal* package in R (Christensen 2018). Given the Brant test results, variables were freed selectively to avoid separation issues. The final partial proportional odds specification released the proportionality constraint for the treatment variable and its interaction with party identification, as well as employment status. Although the likelihood ratio test (LRT) indicated that the PPO model fit significantly better than the constrained ordered logit (LRT = 53.89, df = 18, $p < 0.001$), and AIC favored the partial proportional odds specification (partial proportional odds AIC = 3268.94 versus standard AIC = 3286.83), BIC favored the more parsimonious standard ordered logit (partial proportional odds BIC = 3492.56 versus standard BIC = 3416.84).

We thus opted to treat the standard proportional odds model as the primary model, and the partial proportional odds model as the robustness check for the pre-assassination attempt period sample.

Turning to the post-assassination attempt period, the omnibus test indicated that the parallel regression assumption is violated globally for the sample ($\chi^2 = 209.14$, df = 63, $p < 0.001$), providing clear justification for relaxing the proportionality constraint. Numerous individual predictors provided evidence of non-proportional effects, although the treatment-by-party interaction terms did not violate proportional odds assumption. Due to the global violation, and to assess whether relaxing the proportionality constraint for the offending predictors meaningfully improved model fit, we again estimated a partial proportional odds model. The final partial proportional odds specification released the proportionality constraint for the treatment variable, interpersonal trust, employment status, sex, race, education, and the fixed effect survey timing while retaining proportionality for party identification and the treatment-by-party interaction terms.

This model converged without separation issues, while the likelihood ratio test indicated that the partial proportional odds model fit significantly better than the constrained ordered logit (LRT = 195.23, df = 51, $p < 0.001$). In addition, the AIC strongly favored the partial proportional odds specification (partial proportional odds AIC = 9568.70 versus standard AIC = 9661.92), representing a 93-point improvement. Although BIC favored the more parsimonious standard ordered logit (partial proportional odds BIC = 10055.52 versus standard BIC = 9822.06), the decisive omnibus Brant failure, the overwhelming likelihood ratio test result, and the substantial AIC improvement collectively provide strong justification for treating the partial proportional odds model as the primary specification for the post-assassination attempt period.

From here, we estimated a final robustness check on the data using a pooled sample. Once pooled, we replicated our aforementioned analytical strategy: 100 imputed datasets were generated with 100 iterations each, followed by ATT matching, and testing for the proportional odds assumption. The Brant test on the combined sample model confirms global violation of the proportional odds assumption ($\chi^2 = 351.26$, df = 66, $p < 0.001$). For this reason, we estimated a partial proportional odds model on the combined sample.

Average Marginal Effects

To estimate average marginal effects (AMEs), we used the *marginaleffects* package in R to estimate the predicted probability of each thermometer category (Arel-Bundock et al. 2024). In this way, we estimated the AMEs for social media news exposure, which represents the average difference in the predicted probability of falling into each outcome category between the treated (media exposed) and control (not exposed) conditions, averaged over the observed covariate distribution of the matched sample. AMEs were estimated via stratification by party identification to characterize heterogeneous treatment effects across partisan groups. All AMEs were pooled across imputed datasets via Rubin's (1987) combination rules, and statistical significance was assessed at the conventional $\alpha = 0.05$ threshold using two-tailed tests.

To summarize, due to issues with the proportional odds assumption, we have two sets of findings presented and discussed in the results section. First, we present the proportional odds model AMEs for the pre-assassination attempt period versus the partial proportional odds model AMEs for post-assassination attempt period. Second, for additional robustness and comparison, we estimate a partial proportional odds model based on the pooled sample. We present those partial proportional odds results as AMEs for comparison. We discuss these findings in the section that follows before moving onto the discussion.

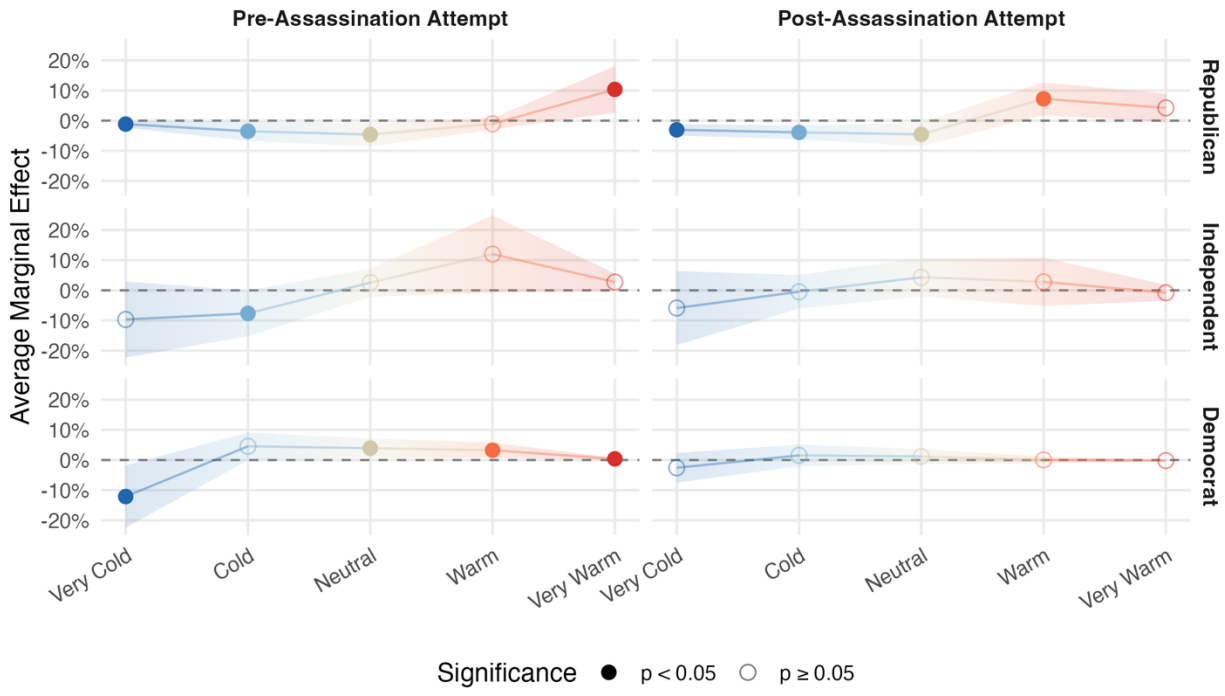
Results

Figure 1 visualizes the proportional odds model AMEs of social media exposure by party on the Trump feeling thermometer categories for the pre-assassination period compared to the partial proportional odds model AMEs for the post-assassination period.[3] The overall pattern across our results suggests that the AME of social media news exposure on evaluative feelings towards Trump differ substantially in both magnitude and distribution across the pre- and post-assassination attempt periods. However, given that the pre-assassination attempt period uses the proportional odds model as its foundation, while the post-assassination period uses the partial proportional odds model, we are careful to directly compare the point estimates for the first set of results. We instead focus on the direction of effects for consistency in the patterns for this first set of analyses.

Among Republicans, we see an interesting pattern that provides preliminary support for our first hypothesis (*The Republican Hypothesis*). In the pre-assassination attempt period, social media exposure significantly reduces the probability of Very Cold (−1.2%), Cold (−3.5%), and Neutral (−4.6%) evaluations at 95% confidence ($p < 0.05$), while significantly increasing the probability of Very Warm evaluations with 99 percent confidence (+10.4%, $p < 0.01$). This pattern seems to demonstrate that Republicans who are already predisposed to supporting Trump are going to continue to do so after being exposed to social media.

[3] The proportional odds regression tables using *polr* and *clm* for both the pre-assassination and post-assassination periods can be found in Appendix Table 1, while the partial proportional odds regression tables using *clm* for both the pre-assassination attempt and post-assassination attempt periods can be found in Appendix Table 2. The equivalent proportional odds AMEs table can be found in Appendix Table 3, while the partial proportional odds AMEs table can be found in Appendix Table 4.

Figure 1. Proportional Odds Pre-Assassination Attempt vs Partial Proportional Odds Post-Assassination Attempt AMEs, by Partisan Identification on Trump Feeling Thermometer Categories



Note: ATT, Matched Sample. Shaded bands = 95% CI. Filled points = p < 0.05. Pooled across 100 imputations using Rubin's rules.
Pre-Assassination Attempt: Proportional Odds model. Post-Assassination Attempt: Partial Proportional Odds model (reduced specification).

The findings in the post-assassination attempt period, which relax the proportionality constraint for the treatment variable, yield slightly different effects although the pattern remains somewhat consistent. Specifically, they suggest social media exposure yielded similar negative evaluation effects among Republicans: Very Cold evaluations at the 99 percent confidence level (−3.0%, $p < 0.01$), Cold evaluations at the 99.9 percent confidence level (−3.9%, $p < 0.001$), and Neutral evaluations at the 95 percent confidence level (−4.5%, $p < 0.05$). However, they also suggest Republicans experienced a significant positive effect for Warm evaluations with 99 percent confidence (+7.3%, $p < 0.01$). Unlike the pre-assassination attempt period, there was a non-significant effect for Very Warm evaluations (+4.2%, $p = 0.079$) among Republicans. These

findings suggest that social media exposure seemingly shifts Republicans toward warm evaluations, but potentially not the most enthusiastic (i.e., Very Warm) evaluations on Trump in the post assassination attempt period. This relationship is reviewed in the pooled sample analyses.

The Independent affiliate findings provide a surprisingly consistent pattern of weak and largely non-significant effects across both periods that provide preliminary mixed support for *The Independent Hypothesis*. In the pre-assassination attempt period, the only statistically significant effect is a negative one at Cold evaluations (−7.6%) with 95 percent confidence ($p < 0.05$). Several non-significant effects include Very Cold (−9.7%, $p = 0.133$) evaluations, Warm (+12%, $p = 0.065$) evaluations, and Very Warm (+2.7%, $p = 0.060$) evaluations. At a minimum, these results suggest a directional pattern where colder evaluations become more negative while warmer evaluations become more positive among Independents, although statistically we can only speak to the Cold evaluation category.

Post-assassination attempt, all effects collapse toward zero and lose significance entirely. In other words, these findings seem to suggest that the assassination attempt homogenized Independent voter evaluations in a way that media exposure could not meaningfully differentiate through this model. At a minimum, the consistency of the null findings across both models may potentially suggest that social media exposure had no meaningful effect on Independent Trump evaluations.

The findings for Democrats also provide preliminary mixed support for *the Democratic Hypothesis*. Starting with the pre-assassination attempt period, Democrats are concentrated among colder evaluation levels, which is expected given Trump's Republican affiliation. However, the model also uncovers unexpected movement toward warmer evaluations in the pre-

assassination period. Specifically, the model suggests that social media exposure significantly reduces the probability of Very Cold evaluations (−12.1%) while modestly but significantly increasing the probability of Neutral evaluations (+3.9%), Warm evaluations (+3.3%), and Very Warm evaluations (+0.4%), all with 95 percent confidence ($p < 0.05$). In other words, media exposure has a similar impact on both Republican and Democratic voter evaluations towards Trump pre-assassination attempt, although this is potentially much more modest among Democrats than Republicans. This is a surprising finding given Trump's partisan identity and his typically polarizing personality among Democrats, which we review in the pooled robustness check model. Before doing this, however, it is important to note that the pattern changes substantially under the partial proportional odds model for the post-assassination period. Here, the findings are overwhelmingly null across all evaluation categories. This potentially signals that social media exposure post-assassination attempt may have minimal to no impact on Democrats.

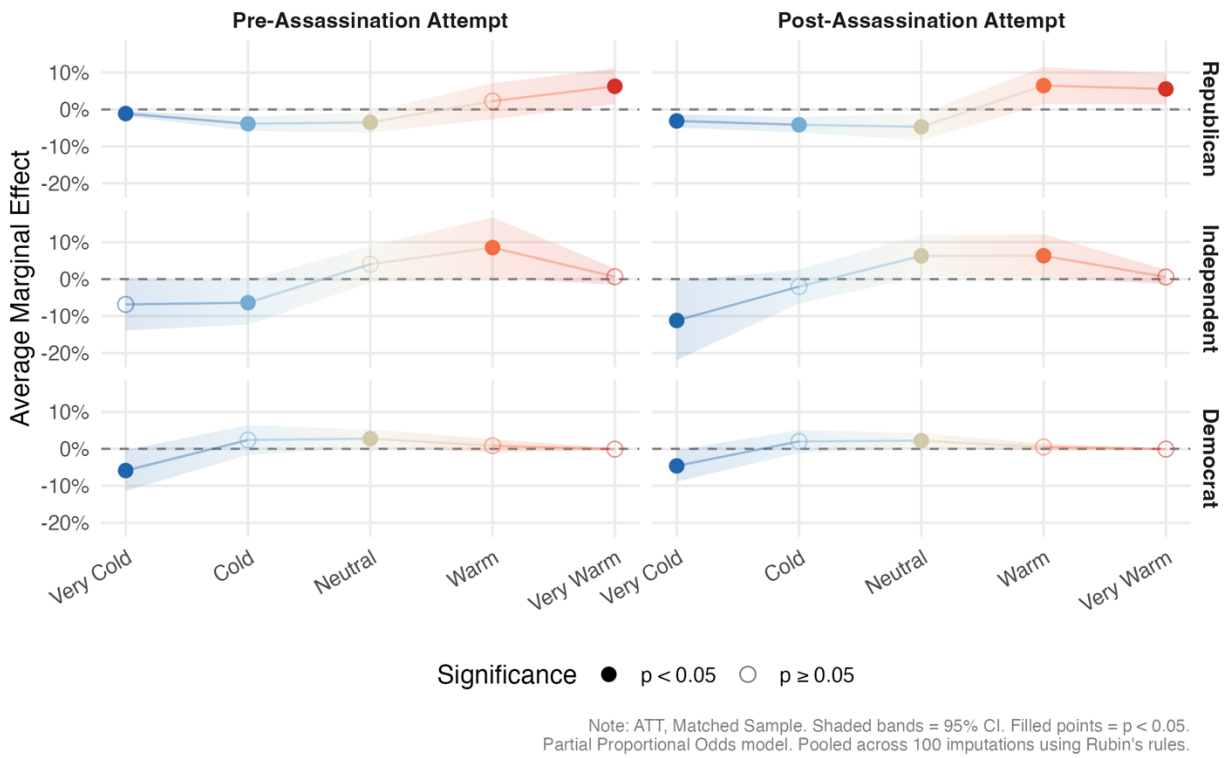
Moving onto the robustness check, Figure 2 visualizes the AMEs for a partial proportional odds model on the pooled sample data.[4] A major benefit behind pooling the data pre-analysis is that both the direction and point-estimates are now comparable given this is one dataset using the partial proportional odds model. In this way, the findings in Figure 2 can more firmly provide support or rejection of our hypotheses.

Starting with Republicans, the results from this analysis suggest social media news exposure produces a consistent and statistically significant movement away from colder evaluations towards Trump to warmer evaluations in both periods. In the pre-assassination attempt period, social media exposure significantly reduces the probability of Very Cold

[4] The proportional odds and partial proportional odds regression tables can be found in Appendix Table 5. The equivalent partial proportional odds AMEs table can be found in Appendix Table 6.

evaluations with 99 percent confidence (−1.1%, $p < 0.01$), Cold evaluations with 99.9 percent confidence (−3.9%, $p < 0.001$), and Neutral evaluations with 95 percent confidence (−3.5%, $p < 0.05$). At the same time, there is a statistically significant increase in Very Warm evaluations towards Trump with 95 percent confidence (+6.3%, $p < 0.05$). While there is a non-significant positive effect at Warm evaluations (+2.2%, $p < 0.365$), the overall pattern in the pre-assassination attempt period is that emotional evaluations toward Trump increased with social media exposure, which is consistent with the results presented under the proportional odds model in Figure 1.

Figure 2. Partial Proportional Odds Combined Sample AMEs: Pre-Assassination Attempt vs Post-Assassination Attempt, by Partisan Identification on Trump Feeling Thermometer Categories



In the post-assassination period, this pattern shifts slightly towards favoring the warm end of the evaluative spectrum with little change in the colder to neutral categories. Indeed, statistically significant negative effects persist for Very Cold evaluations with 99 percent confidence (−3.1%, $p < 0.01$), Cold evaluations with 99.9 percent confidence (−4.2%, $p < 0.001$), and Neutral evaluations with 95 percent confidence (−4.7%, $p < 0.05$). The positive effects are now distributed across both Warm evaluations with 95 percent confidence (+6.4%, $p < 0.05$) and Very Warm evaluations with 95 percent confidence (+5.5%, $p < 0.05$). While the patterns are relatively stable, these findings confirm that the assassination attempt not only broadened the positive treatment effect among Republicans across the warmer categories, but also that warmer evaluations became substantially greater between periods. As warmer evaluations are substantially greater in magnitude in the post-assassination period, it does seem that Trump saw overall warmer evaluations among Republicans.

Among Independent affiliates, we see interesting differences between both periods as well. In the pre-assassination attempt period, exposure produces a significant redistribution from Cold evaluations with 95 percent confidence (−6.4%, $p < 0.05$) toward Warm evaluations with 95 percent confidence (+8.5%, $p < 0.05$), although there is also a borderline non-significant reduction in Very Cold evaluations (−6.8%, $p = 0.056$). However, there was no significant effect for Neutral or Very Warm evaluations in this period. Rather, in the post-assassination attempt period, the pattern changes: the negative effect moves from Cold to Very Cold evaluations with 95 percent significance (−11.2%, $p < 0.05$), with significant positive effects appearing at both Neutral evaluations with 95 percent confidence (+6.3%, $p < 0.05$) and Warm evaluations with 95 percent confidence (+6.3%, $p < 0.05$).

This shift in patterns between periods suggests the assassination attempt altered the threshold in which media exposure operates among Independent affiliates. Specifically, exposure in the post-assassination attempt period pulls Independent affiliates away from the most extreme cold evaluations and spreads this effect more evenly across the moderated categories rather than toward warm evaluations specifically. However, it is important to note that the confidence intervals across both periods are very large and, while the points are statistically significant, caution is warranted in declaring clear support for *The Independent hypothesis*. Trump does at least seemingly become more neutral in the eyes of Independent affiliates.

Findings among Democratic affiliate demonstrated an interesting and consistent pattern across both periods: evaluations are concentrated at the cold end of the distribution. In the pre-assassination attempt period, social media exposure significantly reduces Very Cold evaluations with 95 percent confidence (−5.9%, $p < 0.05$) and modestly but significantly increases Neutral evaluations with 95 percent confidence (+2.7%, $p < 0.05$). However, the findings suggest insignificant effects at warmer categories. This pattern repeats in the post-assassination period, with a significant reduction at Very Cold evaluations with 95 percent confidence (−4.6%, $p < 0.05$), a significant increase at Neutral evaluations with 95 percent confidence (+2.2%, $p < 0.05$), and warmer evaluative categories remain non-significant.

In this way, the evaluative relationship among Democrats is seemingly as follows: social media news exposure consistently moves Democrats from the most extreme cold evaluation toward ambivalence in their evaluations of Trump, although the effects are small. The absence of any significant positive effects beyond Neutral in either period confirms that exposure does not generate positive emotions toward Trump among Democrats. In fact, while comparing the pre-assassination attempt and post-assassination attempt periods effects suggest that Democrat

affiliates' Very Cold evaluations decreased in the latter period, so too did Neutral evaluations decrease. As such, our evidence is mixed as Democrats seemingly became less cold towards Trump at the extremes, but also less neutral. This potentially suggests Democrat emotions towards Trump in the post-assassination period are more mixed, potentially reflecting polarized positions towards Trump due to partisan identity.

Discussion

The findings presented in this study illuminate the central role of social media exposure in shaping affective evaluations of political actors during moments of heightened national salience, of which the most recent example was the attempted assassination of Donald Trump. The effects of social media exposure in this study on evaluative feelings towards Trump are neither uniform across partisan groups nor stable across political contexts. Instead, social media exposure effects are moderated by partisan identity in ways that largely, but do not perfectly, align with deepening or strengthening existing affective predispositions. Yet the findings in this study also suggest that these effects are further conditioned by the political shock of the July 2024 assassination attempt in ways that reveal the fragility of affective equilibria in potential moments of crisis.

The findings in this study are most consistent with support for *The Republican Hypothesis*. Across the pre-assassination attempt and post-assassination attempt periods, social media exposure systematically reduces the probability of cold and neutral evaluations while increasing the probability of warm evaluations among Republican identifiers. In other words, those respondents predisposed toward positive affect for a co-partisan figure were likely to encounter and internalize information that confirms and deepens that predisposition. It is

important to note, however, that there is a distributional shift in positive effects between periods: prior to the assassination attempt, the significant positive effect is concentrated at the Very Warm evaluative category, while in the post-assassination period the significant positive effect spreads across both Warm and Very Warm categories. One interpretation of this pattern is that the assassination attempt may have activated latent sympathy among Republicans who were previously more moderate in their warmth toward Trump, effectively broadening the affective coalition beyond the most committed supporters. This is not unlike rally effects (for examples, see Baker and Oneal, 2001; Chowanietz, 2011), although these are usually temporary effects.

The findings among Independents are more substantively interesting given mixed support that varies considerably by analytical approach and period. In our separate model analyses, effects among Independents are largely null both before and after the assassination attempt, with the collapse of even directional effects in the post-assassination period. The pooled model, however, suggested that Independents display a significant redistribution of evaluations that shifts from colder toward warmer evaluative categories in the pre-assassination attempt period and from the most extreme cold evaluations toward neutral and warm evaluative categories in the post-assassination attempt period. The inconsistency between these sets of results suggests a need for caution, as interpreting either set in isolation may lead to unwarranted confidence and false conclusions. What both approaches do share, however, is the suggestion that exposure does not simply move Independents toward warmer evaluations in a linear fashion. Instead, the assassination attempt appears to have altered the evaluative threshold at which media exposure operates by pulling Independent affiliates away from extreme negativity without generating strong positive affect. This is theoretically consistent with ambivalence models of political evaluation (see Zaller and Feldman, 1992), which suggest that Independents are particularly

susceptible to contextual shocks that restructure, rather than merely shift, their affective orientations. Additional research on Independents is warranted to test whether there are other factors contributing to these effects.

Finally, the Democratic findings are arguably the most consequential for the broader theoretical framework and the most difficult to reconcile with a simple directional hypothesis. Our expectation that Democrats would shift toward colder evaluations of Trump following social media exposure, especially in the post-assassination period, is not supported by either analytical approach. Instead, the results consistently show that exposure moves Democrats away from the most extreme cold evaluations and modestly toward neutral evaluations. In other words, Democrats experience a softening of hostility rather than an intensification effect. This finding challenges the affective polarization as a self-reinforcing cycle in which partisan media exposure deepens negative out-group affect (Iyengar et al. 2019). However, one possible explanation is that the assassination attempt introduced a humanizing frame that temporarily disrupted purely partisan evaluative logic among some Democrats. While this may explain the reduction in extreme cold evaluations observed in the post-assassination period, absence of any significant positive effects beyond the Neutral category in either period confirms a clear affective ceiling: social media exposure does not generate genuine warmth toward Trump among Democrats in 2024, and the softening of hostility that does occur is modest in magnitude and potentially temporary in character.

Conclusion

What impact does a violent attack against a political leader have on cross-partisan candidate sympathy? This study set out to examine whether and how social media news exposure shapes affective evaluations of Donald Trump across partisan groups, and whether the July 2024

assassination attempt altered these dynamics. We found that social media news exposure exerts partisan-asymmetric effects on Trump feeling thermometer evaluations that are further conditioned by political context in substantively important ways. The evidence provides clearest and most consistent support for *The Republican Hypothesis*: exposure systematically shifts Republican affiliates away from cold and neutral evaluations toward warmer ones, with the assassination attempt broadening this positive effect across the two warmer evaluative categories rather than merely intensifying it at extreme levels. Support for *The Independent Hypothesis* is mixed and context-dependent, with the pooled findings suggesting a reorientation of evaluations away from extreme negativity in the post-assassination period, while the separated model analyses provide largely null effects. *The Democratic Hypothesis* is not supported in the expected direction at all. Surprisingly, we found that exposure consistently softens extreme hostility and nudges Democrats modestly toward evaluative ambivalence, without generating any significant positive affective emotions toward Trump in either period.

These findings have implications that extend beyond studying Trump. They suggest that the relationship between social media exposure and political affect is neither uniformly polarizing nor uniformly moderating but is instead conditioned by the interaction of partisan identity predispositions, the evaluative structure of the outcome, and the political context in which exposure occurs. Our findings suggest that models of media influence developed under normal political conditions may require significant revision when applied to crisis or high-salience event contexts.

There are several important limitations to this work that warrant acknowledgment and motivate future research. First, the cross-sectional design of both survey waves means that causal inference, while strengthened by propensity score matching, remains subject to the usual caveats

that attend observational data. Indeed, there are even limitations in the number of variables available for the study given the studies were not treated longitudinally, which severely limit potential hypotheses. Moreover, respondents who are exposed to social media news are not randomly assigned to that exposure condition, and while our matching procedure addresses observable confounders, unmeasured heterogeneity in news-seeking behavior, platform use, and affective predispositions may still bias our estimates in ways we cannot fully adjudicate.

Second, while it is widely used in political science research, the feeling thermometer outcome is not a perfect instrument for capturing the multidimensional nature of political affect. Future work should consider more fine-grained measures of discrete emotions for this purpose, although especially for emotions enthusiasm, anxiety, anger, and contempt, among others. Such measures would be better positioned to characterize the precise affective mechanisms through which social media exposure operates. Third, social media news exposure does not capture variation in what voters actually consume, especially among those more partisan voters. Republicans and Democrats who report equivalent levels of social media news exposure are almost certainly consuming very different information environments, so disentangling the effects of exposure volume from exposure content remains an important task for subsequent research.

Despite these limitations, the study makes a timely and theoretically consequential contribution to the literature. Due to the assassination attempt, the 2024 presidential election cycle provided an unusually demanding test of the hypothesis that social media exposure reinforces partisan affect. That the reinforcement pattern holds most clearly for Republicans, the altering as opposed to simple amplification effect seen in the analyses suggests that the affective politics of social media are more nuanced than either optimistic or pessimistic accounts of media influence have typically acknowledged. The finding that Democrats did indeed move toward

ambivalence rather than deeper hostility is particularly notable in an environment where affective polarization is presumed to be self-reinforcing, which further raises the possibility that the relationship between exposure and negative out-group affect may be contingent and potentially reversible. As political events of extraordinary salience become more rather than less common features of the contemporary American political environment, understanding how social media mediates the affective consequences of those events will remain one of the most pressing questions in political communication and political psychology research.

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